

WEDNESDAY IN THE FIFTH WEEK

AT MATINS

The usual beginning, with the Six psalms, the great Litany and then, in place of “God is the Lord ...,” we chant, in the Tone of the week:

Choir: Alleluia (Thrice)

Verse: Out of the night my spirit waketh at dawn unto Thee, O God, for Thy commandments are light upon the earth. (Alleluia x3)

Verse: Learn righteousness, ye that dwell upon the earth. (Alleluia x3)

Verse: Zeal shall lay hold upon an uninstructed people. (Alleluia x3)

Verse: Add more evils upon them, O Lord; add more evils upon them that are glorious upon the earth. (Alleluia x3)

Then the Choir chanteth the Triadicon (Hymns to the Trinity) in the Tone of the week, each one only once, followed by the 1st chanting of the Psalter (Kathisma XX), the Sessional Hymns from the Oktoechos, in the Tone of the week. After the 2nd chanting of the Psalter (Kathisma I), the Sessional Hymns:

In Tone VIII:

Ungraciously Adam ate from the tree, * and reaped the bitter fruits of his lack of abstinence; * but Thou, O merciful One, lifted up upon the Tree, * didst deliver him from his grievous condemnation, * wherefore we cry to Thee: * Grant us, O Master, temperance that we may abstain * from corrupting fruit, and do Thy will, ** and thereby receive Thy mercy.

Glory ..., the foregoing is repeated.

Both now ..., in Tone VIII:

Stavrotheotokion: Christ took flesh from thy pure blood * and was born from thee, O pure one, * in a manner beyond understanding; * upon seeing Him hung on the Cross between two malefactors, * thy soul was filled with anguish, * and with a mother's lamentation thou didst cry aloud: * “Woe is me, my Child! What is this divine and ineffable condescension, * whereby Thou hast restored to life Thy creature? ** I sing the praises of Thy compassionate goodness.”

After the 3rd chanting of the Psalter (Kathisma II), the Sessional Hymns:

In Tone II:

Singing the praises of the all-holy Tree of the Cross, * we ever venerate Thy boundless love, O Christ God. * For upon it Thou hast put to shame the hosts of the enemy, * and given it as a sign unto those that believe in Thee. * Therefore in thanksgiving we cry aloud to Thee: * Grant that in good faith and in peace ** we may complete the time of the Fast.

Glory ..., the foregoing is repeated.

Both now ..., in Tone II:

Stavrotheotokion: Upon seeing the innocent Shepherd hanging upon the Tree, * the Ewe-Lamb cried aloud with a mother's lamentation: * "O my Son, Thine ungrateful people have condemned to death, * Thee who didst cover them with a cloud as they journeyed through the wilderness; * Woe is me! I have no husband, nor Child. * But, do Thou arise, O Sun, and let Thy light shine forth; ** and I shall be glorified among the sons of mortal men."

Then Psalm 50, after which we chant the canon from the Menaion, and the two three-canticle canons from the Triodion; for those ODES we chant the ODE of the second Triodion canon as Katavasia.

The Canons

ODE III

First canon, by Joseph, in Tone VIII:

Irmos: O Lord, Creator of the vault of Heaven ...,

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

With Thine hands Stretched out upon the Cross, O just Judge, Thou hast condemned enmity; and now save me the prodigal who art condemned by my sins, for I have provoked Thee, O longsuffering Savior.

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

Like a wild beast I have desired a life that inflameth passions; I have departed far from Thy commandments, O Good One, and become the servant of strange and unclean citizens. But do Thou accept me who hath now turned back to Thee, and save me.

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

As of old Thou didst open the ear and tongue of him who had an impediment in his speech, open now the ears of my soul which hath grown deaf in comprehension, and grant them to worthily hear Thy saving words, O Jesus who alone lovest mankind.

Refrain: Most holy Theotokos save us.

Theotokion: **O** Gate of salvation, and Bridge to God, Protector of Christians, O Most holy Lady, I am beset by many troubles and tempest-tossed on the sea of life, do thou O maiden pilot me.

Another canon, by Theodore, in Tone II:

Irmos: **My** mind hath not brought forth good fruit, * but do Thou show me to be fruitful * in Thy compassion O God, * Thou husbandman of all good things.

Refrain: Glory to Thy precious Cross O Lord.

For the sake of Thy compassionate mercy Thou didst ascend the Cross, O Christ, and lift me up from the pit of the passions, raising me to heaven.

Refrain: Glory to Thy precious Cross O Lord.

Stretching out Thy hands upon the Cross, O Christ, Thou hast embraced nations that were far from Thee, drawing them near Thy dominion.

Glory ..., **U**nity in three Hypostases, Trinity supreme in Essence, one Godhead, the Father, the Son and the Spirit of righteousness, save those who honor Thee.

Both now ..., **Theotokion:** **W**ho among those born on earth can praise thee as is meet, O Virgin Mother? For thou, O all-blessed one, alone hast been revealed as chosen among women.

Refrain: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Thou wast lifted up upon the Cross, Thy side pierced, and tasting gall, for my sake, who hath provoked Thee O Jesus, through disobedience.

Katavasia: **My** mind hath not brought forth good fruit, * but do Thou show me to be fruitful * in Thy compassion O God, * Thou husbandman of all good things.

ODE VIII

First canon, in Tone VIII:

Irmos: **In** his wrath the Chaldean Tyrant ...,

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

With Thine unsleeping eye look upon me and have compassion: for I am held fast in the sleep of melancholy and lay upon the bed of passions. Thou didst bow Thine head upon the Cross, O Christ, and willingly awakened from sleep, Thou hast banished the darkness of sin; for Thou art the Light of righteousness.

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

I was richly adorned with Thy gifts at Baptism; but wretched as I am, I have loved the poverty of evil, and become a stranger to virtue, and wandered into the far country of sin: but do Thou turn me back, O Savior, and embrace me, and surround me with Thy Cross throughout the ages.

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

Cast aside, O my soul, the drunkenness of the passions, and by fasting seek the cleansing wine of tears which maketh glad the heart of man, withering lust and extinguishing the burning of the flesh. Make haste therefore to be crucified with Christ, Who for thy sake wast nailed upon the Tree, that thou mayest live with Him throughout all ages.

Refrain: Most holy Theotokos save us.

Theotokion: **O** all-pure Birthgiver of God, cleanse the wounds of my soul and the scars of my many sins, bathing them in the fountain that ever floweth from the side of Him whom thou didst bear, that I may cry to thee, and flee to thee for refuge, and call upon thee, O grace-filled Mother.

Second canon, in Tone II:

Irmos: **Unto God who is glorified in heaven * by the voices of angels; * let us sing, and with every mortal born on earth * let us praise Him throughout all ages.**

Refrain: Glory to Thy precious Cross O Lord.

To Thee who hath been crucified in the flesh, yet didst not suffer in Thy divine nature, O Jesus, do we the race of mortals, and the angels, ever hymn throughout all ages.

Refrain: Glory to Thy precious Cross O Lord.

By Thy Crucifixion, O Christ, and by choosing an accursed and shameful death, Thou hast delivered us from corruption and saved us.

Refrain: We bless the Father, Son and Holy Spirit, the Lord.

With the cherubim, O Trinity, I praise Thee, singing: Holy, Holy, Holy, one Godhead, simple, beginningless, and transcending all understanding.

Both now ..., Theotokion: **I**n songs of praise, O pure one, all generations honor thee with gladness, for thou hast given birth to the Creator, O strange wonder and all-blessed deed!

Refrain: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Solely for the sake of my salvation, O Christ, Thou hast consented to suffer all things. I hymn Thy Crucifixion, the nails and death throughout all ages.

Verse: We praise, we bless, and we worship the Lord ...,

Katavasia: Unto God who is glorified in heaven * by the voices of angels; * let us sing, and with every mortal born on earth * let us praise Him throughout all ages.

ODE IX

First canon, in Tone VIII:

Irmos: Heaven stood amazed and the ends of the earth ...,

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

Upon seeing Thee nailed upon the Cross, the sun hid its rays, and the whole of the earth was seized with trembling, O King of all, beholding Thee willingly suffering, even though by nature Thou art impassible. Wherefore I beseech Thee, heal the passions of my soul O Christ, Thou physician of souls.

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

Having forsaken the paths of salvation, I have traversed the path that leadeth to Hades, and am surrounded by the deep darkness of lust, the slipperiness of passions, and the tempest of temptation; Wherefore I entreat Thee: Save me by Thy Cross, O Christ, for Thou alone art plenteous in mercy.

Refrain: Have mercy on me O God, have mercy on me.

Beset by the wintry storm of temptation, I am drowning amidst the waves of passion, assailed by the tempest of lust; but now that I have reached the sea of the Fast I find mildness and calm. Do Thou pilot me as I traverse it by Thy Cross, O compassionate One, and bring me to the safe-harbor of salvation.

Refrain: Most holy Theotokos save us.

Theotokion: Without seed, O Virgin, and without carnal desire, thou hast conceived the Word of God who hath fashioned all things; and without corruption and the pangs of travail thou hast given birth to Him. Wherefore with both tongue and heart we confess thee to be the very Theotokos and we magnify thee.

Second canon, in Tone II:

Irmos: Thy virginity, O undefiled Theotokos, * was not burnt by the fire of the Divinity, * wherefore we magnify thee.

Refrain: Glory to Thy precious Cross O Lord.

Willingly, O our Savior, didst Thou endure Crucifixion, to deliver us all from death and grant us life.

Refrain: Glory to Thy precious Cross O Lord.

By a tree did I perish, and by the Tree of the Cross I have returned to life: for my Christ was nailed upon it and hath thereby slain the enemy.

Glory ..., **L**et us with one mind worship the Son who coexists with the Father, and the Holy Spirit who is ever present with them.

Both now ..., **Theotokion:** **O** marvelous wonder! O strange tidings! How dost thou give birth as a mother, O pure one, and as a virgin not know corruption?

Refrain: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

I sing of Thy lance, I praise Thy nails, the sponge, the reed and the Cross: for through them I have been saved, O Jesus my God.

Katavasia: **Thy virginity, O undefiled Theotokos, * was not burnt by the fire of the Divinity, * wherefore we magnify thee.**

The small litany.

The Exapostilarion of the day from the Oktoechos; **Glory ...**, the Exapostilarion from the Menaion, if such is appointed; **Both now ...**, the Theotokion.

On the Aposticha, these Stichera in Tone III:

Having Forsaken the height of the virtues, O my soul, * thou hast descended into the depths of sin, and fallen among evil thieves; * wherefore thou art covered with festering sores * laying prostrate and helpless. * But cry aloud unto Christ God, * who, of His own will, hath been crucified and wounded for thy sake, ** saying: "Take care of me, O Lord, and save me."

Verse: We were filled in the morning with Thy mercy, O Lord, and we rejoiced and were glad. In all our days, let us be glad for the days wherein Thou didst humble us, for the years wherein we saw evils. And look upon Thy servants, and upon Thy works, * and do Thou guide their sons.

In Tone VIII:

I the wretched one, have been wounded by thieving thoughts * and left almost dead, O Lord. * The company of the prophets have passed me by, beholding me as one almost dead, * incurable by the hands of man. * Wherefore, in my grievous suffering, * with humble heart I cry unto Thee, O Christ God, * since Thou art compassionate, ** pour upon me Thy great mercy.

Verse: And let the brightness of the Lord our God be upon us, and the works of our hand do Thou guide aright upon us, * yea, the works of our hands do Thou guide aright.

Of the holy martyrs, in Tone VIII:

O ye Invincible martyrs of Christ, * ye triumphed over delusion by the power of the Cross, * and received the grace of eternal life as your reward. * Ye feared not the threatening of the tyrants, * and when ye suffered torments ye rejoiced; * and now your blood hath become for us the healing of our souls. ** Intercede for us, that we be saved.

Glory ..., Both now ..., in Tone VIII:

Stavrotheotokion: Upon seeing Thee hanging upon the Cross in the flesh * the all-pure one was wounded in the depths of her soul, * and she cried aloud with tears: * “O Word, to where hast Thou gone, * O most beloved Jesus, my Son and my Lord? ** leave me not alone who hath given birth to Thee, O Christ.”

Then: It is good to give thanks unto the Lord ..., Trisagion through Our Father ..., then:

Reader: Amen. Standing in the temple of thy glory as though seemingly in heaven; O Theotokos thou gate of heaven, open the door of thy compassion.

Lord have mercy. (40 Times)

Glory ..., Both now ..., Amen.

More honorable than the Cherubim, and beyond compare more glorious than the Seraphim; who without corruption gavest birth to God the Word, the very Theotokos, thee do we magnify.

In the name of the Lord, father (master) bless.

Priest: He that is blessed, Christ our God, always, now and ever, and unto the ages of ages.

Reader: Amen. O Heavenly King, strengthen Orthodox Christians, establish the Faith, subdue the nations, give peace to the world, keep well this city (or habitation, or town); settle our departed fathers and brethren in the tabernacles of the righteous, and receive us in penitence and confession, for Thou art good and the Lover of mankind.

Then the Prayer of St Ephraim:

Priest: O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of idleness, despondency, ambition, and idle talking give me not. (Prostration)

But rather a spirit of chastity, humble-mindedness, patience, and love bestow upon me Thy servant. (Prostration)

Yea, O Lord King, grant me to see my own failings and not condemn my brother; for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages. Amen. (Prostration)

O God, cleanse me a sinner. (Twelve times)

O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of idleness, despondency, ambition, and idle talking give me not. But rather a spirit of chastity, humble-mindedness, patience, and love bestow upon me Thy servant. Yea, O Lord King, grant me to see my own failings and not condemn my brother; for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages. Amen. (Prostration)

Then the reader immediately beginneth the first hour. With the reading of the 3rd Kathisma. The 4th Kathisma is read at the Third Hour, the 5th at the Sixth Hour, the 6th at the Ninth Hour.

SIXTH HOUR

Troparion of the prophecy, in Tone I:

O Lord, accept the sufferings of the saints, * which they endured for Thy sake, * as prayers of intercession, * and we pray Thee, ** heal all our infirmities O Lover of mankind.

Glory ..., Both now ..., the foregoing is repeated.

Prokeimenon, in Tone IV:

Prokeimenon: It is a good to give praise unto the Lord, * and to chant unto Thy Name, O Most High.

Verse: To proclaim in the morning Thy mercy, and Thy truth by night.

THE READING IS FROM THE PROPHECY OF ISAIAH (41: 4 - 14)

Thus saith the Lord: I the Lord, am the first, and with the last; I am he. The isles saw it, and feared; the ends of the earth were afraid, drew near, and came. They helped every one his neighbour; and every one said to his brother, Be of good courage. So the carpenter encouraged the goldsmith, and he that smootheth with the hammer him that smote the anvil, saying, It is ready for the soldering: and he fastened it with nails, that it should not be moved. But thou, Israel, art my servant, Jacob whom I have chosen, the seed of Abraham my friend. Thou whom I have taken from the ends of the earth, and called thee from the chief men thereof, and said unto thee, Thou art my servant; I have chosen thee, and not cast thee away. Fear thou not; for I am with thee: be not dismayed; for I am thy God: I will strengthen thee; yea, I will help thee; yea, I will uphold thee with the right hand of my righteousness. Behold, all they that were incensed against thee shall be ashamed and confounded: they shall be as nothing; and they that strive with thee shall perish. Thou shalt seek them, and shalt not find them, even them that contended with thee: they that war against thee shall be as nothing, and as a thing of naught. For I the Lord thy God will hold thy right hand, saying unto thee, Fear not; I will help thee. Fear not, thou worm Jacob, and ye men of Israel; I will help thee, saith the Lord, and thy redeemer, the Holy One of Israel.

Prokeimenon, in Tone VI:

Prokeimenon: The Lord is King, * He is clothed with majesty.

Verse: The Lord is clothed with strength and He hath girt Himself.

WEDNESDAY IN THE FIFTH WEEK
AT VESPERS

After the Psalm of Introduction (Psalm 103) and the great Litany, instead of the usual Kathisma, we read Kathisma VII.

On “Lord, I have cried ...,” we chant the following Stichera:
(beginning at the following verse of the Psalm “Set O Lord a watch ...”)

In Tone VIII:

Verse: The sinners shall fall into their own net: * I am alone until I pass by.

By my thoughts I have fallen among thieves, * and in my wretchedness my mind hath been taken captive, and cruelly beaten; * my soul is entirely wounded, and stripped of virtues, * and I lie naked on the path of life. * Seeing me in pain with un-healable wounds, * the priest was unable to even glance at me. * the Levite upon seeing me passed by on the other side. * But Thou, O Christ God, wast well-pleased to come, not from Samaria * but incarnate from Mary: * and in Thy love for mankind, grant me healing ** pouring upon me Thy great mercy.

Verse: With my voice unto the Lord have I cried, * with my voice unto the Lord have I made supplication.

Repeat: **By** my thoughts I have fallen among thieves ...,

Verse: I will pour out before Him my supplication, * mine affliction before Him will I declare

Of the holy martyrs, in Tone VIII:

If there be any virtue * and if there be any praise, * rightly are these things ascribed to the saints. * They bowed their necks beneath the sword, * for the sake of Thee who hath bowed the heavens and descended. * They shed their blood for Thee, who hath emptied Thyself and taken the form of a servant; * they humbled themselves even unto death, * following the example of Thy poverty. * By their prayers have mercy on us, O God, ** according to the multitude of Thy great mercy.

By Joseph in Tone VIII:

Verse: When my spirit was fainting within me: * Then thou knewest my paths.

O Lord, Thou hast shown Thy holy disciples to be living heavens. * By their intercessions * deliver me from earthly wickedness, * and through abstinence always raise my thoughts on high * that I may comprehend Thy Passion: * for Thou art merciful and the Lover of mankind.

Verse: In this way wherein I have walked * they hid for me a snare.

Having the season of the Fast * as an aid in the performance of divine deeds. * Let us weep with our whole heart * and cry unto the Savior: * Through Thy disciples, O greatly merciful Lord, * save us who with love praise Thee ** for Thou art compassionate and the Lover of mankind.

By Theodore in Tone VIII:

Verse: I looked on my right hand, and behold: * and there was none that did know me.

O ye all-famed apostles, * intercessors for the whole world, * physicians of the ailing, guardians of the healthy, * in both do ye watch over us during the passing of the fast; * may we remain in blessed peace with one another; * preserving our mind untroubled by the passions, * that all of us may sing a hymn of praise ** to the risen Christ the Conqueror.

By Simeon the translator in Tone IV:

Verse: Flight hath failed me, * and there is none that watcheth out for my soul

I have wasted all my life with harlots and publicans: * how shall I repent, even in my old age, * of the sins that I have committed? * But O Fashioner of all that is and Healer of the sick, ** before I utterly perish O Lord, save me.

Verse: I cried unto Thee, O Lord, I said: * Thou art my hope, my portion art Thou in the land of the living.

Weighed down by the burden of negligence, * I wallow in the mire, pierced by the arrows of forbidden things, * and have defiled my nature created according to Thine image. * O Thou who dost convert the negligent * and deliver those who have sinned, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Attend unto my supplication: * for I am brought very low.

I have become a stumbling-block to men; * born of the earth, I have cultivated earthly things. * By Thy command I was joined in marriage, * and having transgressed I have defiled my bed. * O Thou who hast formed me from the dust of the earth, despise not Thy creature; ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Deliver me them that persecute me: * for they are stronger than I.

Taking my flesh into consideration, * I have become the slayer of my soul. * I have made myself a plaything of devils * and a slave to sinful pleasures. * But do Thou In Thy merciful compassion spare me, * O Thou Banisher of the demons: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Bring my soul out of prison: * that I may praise Thy Name.

I have willfully sinned More than all mankind, * for which I have been forsaken, * I have as an adversary of my soul, * thoughts of the flesh which darken me. * O Light of those in darkness, * and Guide of all who go astray, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: The righteous shall wait patiently for me: * until Thou shalt reward me.

My soul liveth, saith the Prophet O Lord. * and doth praise Thee * Seek me, Thy lost sheep, and number me among Thy chosen flock. * Grant me time for repentance, * that with sorrow I may call upon Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Out of the depths have I cried unto Thee, O Lord: * O Lord, hear my voice.

I have sinned, O Christ God, I have sinned, * having rejected Thine ordinances. * But do Thou be merciful to me, O Benefactor: * that I may see with my noetic eyes, * and escape from the inner darkness, * and cry to Thee in fear: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Let Thine ears be attentive: * to the voice of my supplication.

Wild beasts encompass me: * do Thou snatch me from them, O Master; * for it is Thy will that all men should be saved * and come to the knowledge of the truth. * As Creator, save them all, * and with them all save me: ** before I utterly perish, save me, O Lord.

Verse: If Thou, shouldest mark iniquities O Lord: O Lord, who shall stand? * For with Thee there is forgiveness.

Be Thou my healing O my Benefactor, Redeemer and Savior, * turn not away from me upon seeing me laying in transgressions, * but raise me up as Thou art all-powerful; * That I may confess my deeds and cry to Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: For Thy Name's sake have I waited patiently for Thee, O Lord: my soul hath patiently waited for Thy word, * my soul hath hoped in the Lord.

I have hidden the talent that was given me, * and like the foolish servant, buried it in the ground; * wherefore I have been condemned as of no use, * and no longer dare ask of Thee for anything. * But be Thou not angered with me, rather be compassionate, * that I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: From the morning watch until night, from the morning watch: *
let Israel hope in the Lord.

Thou didst dry up the source of suffering * of the woman with an issue of blood * when she touched the hem of Thy garment, * grant forgiveness of sins unto me also, * who approach Thee with unwavering faith, * do Thou accept me as Thou didst once accept her, * and heal my illness: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: For with the Lord there is mercy, and with Him is plenteous redemption: * and He shall redeem Israel out of all his iniquities.

Upon a throne shalt Thou sit, * who hast created heaven and earth by Thy word, O Lord, * and we all shall stand in Thy presence and confess our sins to Thee. * Before that day cometh, * do Thou accept me in repentance: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Praise the Lord, all ye nations: praise Him, all ye peoples.

Look upon me with a compassionate eye * and be merciful to me, O only Savior. * Grant springs of healing water to my poor and wretched soul, * wash me clean from the filth of my deeds, * that I may sing to Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: For His mercy is great towards us: * and the truth of the Lord abideth for ever.

The adversary hath prepared his weapons * and hasteneth to ensnare my humble soul; * and hath made me, O compassionate One, * a stranger to the resplendence of the contemplation of Thy countenance. * But since Thou art mighty in strength, snatch me from his snares. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Unto Thee have I lifted up mine eyes, unto Thee that dwellest in heaven. Behold, as the eyes of servants look unto the hands of their masters, as the eyes of the handmaid look unto the hands of her mistress, so do our eyes look unto the Lord our God, * until He take pity on us.

I am utterly enslaved by the passions, * I have forsaken the Law and the Holy Scriptures. * Heal all of me, O Benefactor, * who for my sake hast become as I am O Good One. * Turn me back, O Compassionate One, * Thou destroyer of the passions. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Have mercy on us, O Lord, have mercy on us, for greatly are we filled with abasement. Greatly hath our soul been filled therewith; let reproach come upon them that prosper, * and abasement on the proud.

The Harlot washed Thy pure and precious feet with her tears, * and doth thereby encourage all men to approach Thee * and receive the remission of their sins. * Grant also unto me her faith, O Savior, * that I may cry to Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Cleanse the filth from my soul, * O Thou who for my sake wast made poor * and didst become a child according to the flesh. * I am a weak and wretched vessel, O Christ: * send down unto me a drop of Thy mercy; * that I may wash away the dirt and be healed of my sickness. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Strengthen my soul, O Master, * that it may flee to Thee and ever serve Thee; * for Thou art my guardian and protection, * my defense and succor. * Count me worthy, O Word of God, to cry unto Thee with boldness. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Be Thou our unshakable rampart, * O Savior Jesus, and merciful God; * for we have fallen into deceitful ways and deeds. * Do Thou raise up, O Benefactor, Thy creature, * and reconcile it to Thyself O Compassionate One. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

I have become a Prodigal Son, * and having wasted my riches I now perish from hunger. * I seek refuge beneath Thy protection: * accept me as Thou didst accept him O good Father. * Grant me a place at Thy table, * that I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Out of envy the author of evil * drove first-formed man from Paradise. * But the thief who cried out upon the Cross * “Remember me”, regained Paradise. * With faith and fear I also cry to Thee, “Remember me.” ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Stretch out Thine hand to me, * as Thou didst once to Peter, O God, * and having raised me up from the abyss, grant me grace and mercy, * by the supplications of Thy most immaculate Mother * who hath given birth to Thee seedlessly, * and by the prayers of all Thy saints. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Do Thou accept me as one who doth hymn Thee, * O Lamb who taketh away my sins, * for into Thy hands have I committed my soul and body, * and as is my bound duty night and day * I cry unto Thee saying: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Glory ..., **I**neffable is Thy compassionate goodness, * O supremely good One, * be not wrathful, O Lord, * but since Thou art sinless and merciful, * cast me not away from Thy presence, * that with thanksgiving and rejoicing I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Both now ..., **Theotokion:** **O** condescension beyond speech! * O strange and wondrous birth! * How doth the Virgin carry Thee as a child in her arms, * for Thou art her Creator and her God! * O Benefactor who hath thus consented to take flesh from her flesh, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Then, “O joyous Light ...”:

Prokeimenon, in Tone IV:

Prokeimenon: The Lord is the God of vengeance: * the God of vengeance hath spoken openly.

Verse: Be Thou exalted, O Thou that Judgest the earth: render the proud their due.

A READING FROM THE BOOK OF GENESIS (17: 1-9)

When Abram was ninety years old and nine, the Lord appeared to Abram, and said unto him, I am the Almighty God; walk before me, and be thou perfect. And I will make my covenant between me and thee, and will multiply thee exceedingly. And Abram fell on his face: and God talked with him, saying, As for me, behold, my covenant is with thee, and thou shalt be a father of many

nations. Neither shall thy name any more be called Abram, but thy name shall be Abraham; for a father of many nations have I made thee. And I will make thee exceeding fruitful, and I will make nations of thee, and kings shall come out of thee. And I will establish my covenant between me and thee and thy seed after thee in their generations for an everlasting covenant, to be a God unto thee, and to thy seed after thee. And I will give unto thee, and to thy seed after thee, the land wherein thou art a stranger, all the land of Canaan, for an everlasting possession; and I will be their God. And God said unto Abraham, Thou shalt keep my covenant therefore, thou, and thy seed after thee in their generations.

Prokeimenon, in Tone IV:

Prokeimenon: O sing unto the Lord a new song: * sing unto the Lord, all the earth.

Verse: Sing unto the Lord: bless His Name.

A READING FROM THE BOOK OF PROVERBS (15:20 - 16:9)

A wise son maketh a glad father: but a foolish man despiseth his mother. Folly is joy to him that is destitute of wisdom: but a man of understanding walketh uprightly. Without counsel purposes are disappointed: but in the multitude of counselors they are established. A man hath joy by the answer of his mouth: and a word spoken in due season, how good is it! The way of life is above to the wise, that he may depart from hell beneath. The Lord will destroy the house of the proud: but he will establish the border of the widow. The thoughts of the wicked are an abomination to the Lord: but the words of the pure are pleasant words. He that is greedy of gain troubleth his own house; but he that hateth gifts shall live. The heart of the righteous studieth to answer: but the mouth of the wicked poureth out evil things. The Lord is far from the wicked: but he heareth the prayer of the righteous. The light of the eyes rejoiceth the heart: and a good report maketh the bones fat. The ear that heareth the reproof of life abideth among the wise. He that refuseth instruction despiseth his own soul: but he that heareth reproof getteth understanding. The fear of the Lord is the instruction of wisdom; and before honour is humility. The preparations of the heart in man, and the answer of the tongue, is from the Lord. All the ways of a man are clean in his own eyes; but the Lord weigheth the spirits. Commit thy works unto the Lord, and thy thoughts shall be established. The Lord hath made all things for himself: yea, even the wicked for the day of evil. Every one that is proud in heart is an abomination to the Lord: though hand join in hand, he shall not be unpunished. By mercy and truth iniquity is purged: and by the fear of the Lord men depart from evil. When a

man's ways please the Lord, he maketh even his enemies to be at peace with him. Better is a little with righteousness than great revenues without right. A man's heart deviseth his way: but the Lord directeth his steps.

And the rest of the Liturgy of the Presanctified Gifts.

WEDNESDAY VESPERS

(WHEN NOT SERVING THE LITURGY OF THE PRESANCTIFIED GIFTS)

If there is no Liturgy of the Presanctified Gifts: On “Lord, I have cried ...,” we chant the following, starting from the following verse of “set O Lord a watch ...,” in Tone VIII:

Verse: When my spirit was fainting within me: * Then thou knewest my paths.

O Lord, Thou hast shown Thy holy disciples to be living heavens. * By their intercessions * deliver me from earthly wickedness, * and through abstinence always raise my thoughts on high * that I may comprehend Thy Passion: * for Thou art merciful and the Lover of mankind.

Verse: In this way wherein I have walked * they hid for me a snare.

Having the season of the Fast * as an aid in the performance of divine deeds. * Let us weep with our whole heart * and cry unto the Savior: * Through Thy disciples, O most merciful Lord, * save us who with love praise Thee ** for Thou art compassionate and the Lover of mankind.

By Theodore in Tone VIII:

Verse: I looked on my right hand, and behold: * and there was none that did know me.

O ye all-famed apostles, * intercessors for the whole world, * physicians of the ailing, guardians of the healthy, * in both do ye watch over us during the passing of the fast; * may we remain in blessed peace with one another; * preserving our mind untroubled by the passions, * that all of us may sing a hymn of praise ** to the risen Christ the Conqueror.

By Simeon the translator; in Tone IV:

Verse: Flight hath failed me, * and there is none that watcheth out for my soul

I have wasted all my life with harlots and publicans: * how shall I repent, even in my old age, * of the sins that I have committed? * But O Fashioner of all that is and Healer of the sick, ** before I utterly perish O Lord, save me.

Verse: I cried unto Thee, O Lord, I said: * Thou art my hope, my portion art Thou in the land of the living.

Weighed down by the burden of negligence, * I wallow in the mire, pierced by the arrows of forbidden things, * and have defiled my nature created according to Thine image. * O Thou who dost convert the negligent * and deliver those who have sinned, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Attend unto my supplication: * for I am brought very low.

I have become a stumbling-block to men; * born of the earth, I have cultivated earthly things. * By Thy command I was joined in marriage, * and having transgressed I have defiled my bed. * O Thou who hast formed me from the dust of the earth, despise not Thy creature; ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Deliver me them that persecute me: * for they are stronger than I.

Taking my flesh into consideration, * I have become the slayer of my soul. * I have made myself a plaything of devils * and a slave to sinful pleasures. * But do Thou In Thy merciful compassion spare me, * O Thou Banisher of the demons: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Bring my soul out of prison: * that I may praise Thy Name.

I have willfully sinned More than all mankind, * for which I have been forsaken, * I have as an adversary of my soul, * thoughts of the flesh which darken me. * O Light of those in darkness, * and Guide of all who go astray, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: The righteous shall wait patiently for me: * until Thou shalt reward me.

My soul liveth, saith the Prophet O Lord. * and doth praise Thee * Seek me, Thy lost sheep, and number me among Thy chosen flock. * Grant me time for repentance, * that with sorrow I may call upon Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Out of the depths have I cried unto Thee, O Lord: * O Lord, hear my voice.

I have sinned, O Christ God, I have sinned, * having rejected Thine ordinances. * But do Thou be merciful to me, O Benefactor: * that I may see with my noetic eyes, * and escape from the inner darkness, * and cry to Thee in fear: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Let Thine ears be attentive: * to the voice of my supplication.

Wild beasts encompass me: * do Thou snatch me from them, O Master; * for it is Thy will that all men should be saved * and come to the knowledge of the truth. * As Creator, save them all, * and with them all save me: ** before I utterly perish, save me, O Lord.

Verse: If Thou, shouldest mark iniquities O Lord: O Lord, who shall stand? * For with Thee there is forgiveness.

Be Thou my healing O my Benefactor, Redeemer and Savior, * turn not away from me upon seeing me laying in transgressions, * but raise me up as Thou art all-powerful; * That I may confess my deeds and cry to Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: For Thy Name's sake have I waited patiently for Thee, O Lord: my soul hath patiently waited for Thy word, * my soul hath hoped in the Lord.

I have hidden the talent that was given me, * and like the foolish servant, buried it in the ground; * wherefore I have been condemned as of no use, * and no longer dare ask of Thee for anything. * But be Thou not angered with me, rather be compassionate, * that I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: From the morning watch until night, from the morning watch: * let Israel hope in the Lord.

Thou didst dry up the source of suffering * of the woman with an issue of blood * when she touched the hem of Thy garment, * grant forgiveness of sins unto me also, * who approach Thee with unwavering faith, * do Thou accept me as Thou didst once accept her, * and heal my illness: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: For with the Lord there is mercy, and with Him is plenteous redemption: * and He shall redeem Israel out of all his iniquities.

Upon a throne shalt Thou sit, * who hast created heaven and earth by Thy word, O Lord, * and we all shall stand in Thy presence and confess our sins to Thee. * Before that day cometh, * do Thou accept me in repentance: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Praise the Lord, all ye nations: praise Him, all ye peoples.

Look upon me with a compassionate eye * and be merciful to me, O only Savior. * Grant springs of healing water to my poor and wretched soul, * wash me clean from the filth of my deeds, * that I may sing to Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: For His mercy is great towards us: * and the truth of the Lord abideth for ever.

The adversary hath prepared his weapons * and hasteneth to ensnare my humble soul; * and hath made me, O compassionate One, * a stranger to the resplendence of the contemplation of Thy countenance. * But since Thou art

mighty in strength, snatch me from his snares. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

I am utterly enslaved by the passions, * I have forsaken the Law and the Holy Scriptures. * Heal all of me, O Benefactor, * who for my sake hast become as I am O Good One. * Turn me back, O Compassionate One, * Thou destroyer of the passions. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

The Harlot washed Thy pure and precious feet with her tears, * and doth thereby encourage all men to approach Thee * and receive the remission of their sins. * Grant also unto me her faith, O Savior, * that I may cry to Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Cleanse the filth from my soul, * O Thou who for my sake wast made poor * and didst become a child according to the flesh. * I am a weak and wretched vessel, O Christ: * send down unto me a drop of Thy mercy; * that I may wash away the dirt and be healed of my sickness. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Strengthen my soul, O Master, * that it may flee to Thee and ever serve Thee; * for Thou art my guardian and protection, * my defense and succor. * Deem me worthy, O Word of God, to cry unto Thee with boldness. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Be Thou our unshakable rampart, * O Savior Jesus, and merciful God; * for we have fallen into deceitful ways and deeds. * Do Thou raise up, O Benefactor, Thy creature, * and reconcile it to Thyself O Compassionate One. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

I have become a Prodigal Son, * and having wasted my riches I now perish from hunger. * I seek refuge beneath Thy protection: * accept me as Thou didst accept him O good Father. * Deem me worthy to have a place at Thy table, * that I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.

Out of envy the author of evil * drove first-formed man from Paradise. * But the thief who cried out upon the Cross * “Remember me”, regained Paradise. * With faith and fear I also cry to Thee, “Remember me.” ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: *Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.*

Stretch out Thine hand to me, * as Thou didst once to Peter, O God, * and having raised me up from the abyss, grant me grace and mercy, * by the supplications of Thy most immaculate Mother * who hath given birth to Thee seedlessly, * and by the prayers of all Thy saints. ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Verse: *Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee.*

Do Thou accept me as who doth hymn Thee, * O Lamb who taketh away my sins, * for into Thy hands have I committed my soul and body, * and as is my bound duty night and day * I cry unto Thee saying: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Glory ..., Ineffable is Thy compassionate goodness, * O supremely good One, * be not wrathful, O Lord, * but since Thou art sinless and merciful, * cast me not away from Thy presence, * that with thanksgiving and rejoicing I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Both now ..., Theotokion: **O** condescension beyond speech! * O strange and wondrous birth! * How doth the Virgin carry Thee as a child in her arms, * for Thou art her Creator and her God! * O Benefactor who hath thus consented to take flesh from her flesh, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

“O joyous Light ...”:

Prokeimenon, in Tone IV:

Prokeimenon: *The Lord is the God of vengeance: * the God of vengeance hath spoken openly.*

Verse: *Be Thou exalted, O Thou that Judgest the earth: render the proud their due.*

A READING FROM THE BOOK OF GENESIS (17: 1-9)

When Abram was ninety years old and nine, the Lord appeared to Abram, and said unto him, I am the Almighty God; walk before me, and be thou perfect. And I will make my covenant between me and thee, and will multiply thee exceedingly. And Abram fell on his face: and God talked with him, saying, As for me, behold, my covenant is with thee, and thou shalt be a father of many nations. Neither shall thy name any more be called Abram, but thy name shall

be Abraham; for a father of many nations have I made thee. And I will make thee exceeding fruitful, and I will make nations of thee, and kings shall come out of thee. And I will establish my covenant between me and thee and thy seed after thee in their generations for an everlasting covenant, to be a God unto thee, and to thy seed after thee. And I will give unto thee, and to thy seed after thee, the land wherein thou art a stranger, all the land of Canaan, for an everlasting possession; and I will be their God. And God said unto Abraham, Thou shalt keep my covenant therefore, thou, and thy seed after thee in their generations. This is my covenant, which ye shall keep, between me and you and thy seed after thee; Every man child among you shall be circumcised. And ye shall circumcise the flesh of your foreskin; and it shall be a token of the covenant betwixt me and you. And he that is eight days old shall be circumcised among you, every man child in your generations, he that is born in the house, or bought with money of any stranger, which is not of thy seed. He that is born in thy house, and he that is bought with thy money, must needs be circumcised: and my covenant shall be in your flesh for an everlasting covenant. And the uncircumcised man child whose flesh of his foreskin is not circumcised, that soul shall be cut off from his people; he hath broken my covenant. And God said unto Abraham, As for Sarai thy wife, thou shalt not call her name Sarai, but Sarah shall her name be. And I will bless her, and give thee a son also of her: yea, I will bless her, and she shall be a mother of nations; kings of people shall be of her. Then Abraham fell upon his face, and laughed, and said in his heart, Shall a child be born unto him that is an hundred years old? and shall Sarah, that is ninety years old, bear? And Abraham said unto God, O that Ishmael might live before thee! And God said, Sarah thy wife shall bear thee a son indeed; and thou shalt call his name Isaac: and I will establish my covenant with him for an everlasting covenant, and with his seed after him.

On the Aposticha, these Stichera in Tone VIII:

By my thoughts I have fallen among thieves, * and in my wretchedness my mind hath been taken captive, and cruelly beaten; * my soul is entirely wounded, and stripped of virtues, * and I lie naked on the path of life. * Seeing me in pain with un-healable wounds, * the priest was unable to even glance at me. * the Levite upon seeing me passed by on the other side. * But Thou, O Christ God, wast well-pleased to come, not from Samaria * but incarnate from Mary: * and in Thy love for mankind, grant me healing ** pouring upon me Thy great mercy.

Verse: Unto Thee have I lifted up mine eyes, unto Thee that dwellest in heaven. Behold, as the eyes of servants look unto the hands of their

masters, as the eyes of the handmaid look unto the hands of her mistress, so do our eyes look unto the Lord our God, * until He take pity on us.

Repeat: **B**y my thoughts I have fallen among thieves ...,

Verse: Have mercy on us, O Lord, have mercy on us, for greatly are we filled with abasement. Greatly hath our soul been filled therewith; let reproach come upon them that prosper, * and abasement on the proud.

Of the holy martyrs, in Tone VIII:

If there be any virtue * and if there be any praise, * rightly are these things ascribed to the saints. * They bowed their necks beneath the sword, * for the sake of Thee who hath bowed the heavens and descended. * They shed their blood for Thee, who hath emptied Thyself and taken the form of a servant; * they humbled themselves even unto death, * following the example of Thy poverty. * By their prayers have mercy upon us, O God, ** according to the multitude of Thy mercies.

Glory ..., **I**neffable is Thy compassionate goodness, * O supremely good One, * be not wrathful, O Lord, * but since Thou art sinless and merciful, * cast me not away from Thy presence, * that with thanksgiving and rejoicing I may cry unto Thee: ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

Both now ..., **Theotokion:** **O** condescension beyond speech! * O strange and wondrous birth! * How doth the Virgin carry Thee as a child in her arms, * for Thou art her Creator and her God! * O Benefactor who hath thus consented to take flesh from her flesh, ** O Lord, before I utterly perish, save me.

“Now lettest Thou Thy servant ...,” Trisagion through Our Father ..., Then:

In Tone V:

O Theotokos and Virgin, rejoice, O Mary, full of grace; the Lord is with thee; blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the Fruit of thy womb, for thou hast borne the Savior of our souls. **(Prostration)**

Glory ...,

O Baptist of Christ, be mindful of us all, that we may be delivered from our iniquities, for unto thee is given the grace to pray on behalf of us all. **(Prostration)**

Both now ...,

Pray for us, holy apostles and all ye saints, that we may be delivered from perils and afflictions: for ye are our fervent supplicants before the Savior.
(Prostration)

We take refuge beneath thy tender mercy O Theotokos: despise not our supplications in distress: but deliver us from perils, for thou alone art pure and blessed. (No Prostration)

Lord have mercy (40 Times)

Glory ..., Both now ...,

More honorable than the cherubim, and beyond compare more glorious than the seraphim, who without corruption gavest birth to God the word, the very Theotokos thee do we magnify.

In the name of the Lord father (master) bless!

Priest: He that is blessed, Christ our God, always, now and ever, and unto the ages of ages.

Reader: Amen. O Heavenly King, strengthen Orthodox Christians, establish the Faith, subdue the nations, give peace to the world, keep well this city (or habitation, or town); settle our departed fathers and brethren in the tabernacles of the righteous, and receive us in penitence and confession, for Thou art good and the Lover of mankind.

Then the Prayer of St Ephraim:

Priest: O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of idleness, despondency, ambition, and idle talking give me not. (Prostration)

But rather a spirit of chastity, humble-mindedness, patience, and love bestow upon me Thy servant. (Prostration)

Yea, O Lord King, grant me to see my own failings and not condemn my brother; for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages. Amen. (Prostration)

O God, cleanse me a sinner. (Twelve times)

O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of idleness, despondency, ambition, and idle talking give me not. But rather a spirit of chastity, humble-mindedness, patience, and love bestow upon me Thy servant. Yea, O Lord King, grant me to see my own failings and not condemn my brother; for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages. Amen. (Prostration)

Reader: Holy God, Holy Mighty ..., Our Father ...,

Priest: For Thine is the Kingdom ...,

Lord Have Mercy (12 Times)

.Priest: Glory to Thee, O Christ God our hope, glory be to Thee

Choir: Glory ..., Both now ..., Amen, Lord, have mercy (Thrice), Father (Master), Bless.

Priest: (The dismissal)

Note: Oil and wine are allowed in the refectory on account of the labors of the coming vigil. Small Compline, without bows, is said in the cells. After the Trisagion, we read the Kontakion of the Great Canon:

Kontakion of the great canon, in Tone VI:

○ My soul, O my soul, * arise! Why dost thou sleep? * The end draweth near, and thou shalt be confounded, * awake then and be watchful * that Christ thy God may spare thee, ** for He is everywhere present, and fillest all things.

Also, the Midnight Office, is likewise said in the cells, with the same Kontakion.

Note: The Office of Matins for Thursday is chanted on Wednesday evening, not on Thursday morning.